The Negro Speaks of Rivers

Langston Hughes · published in The Crisis · June 1921 · poem in full

Source: Langston Hughes, 'The Negro Speaks of Rivers,' The Crisis (June 1921), text via the Poetry Foundation. Published 1921; public domain in the United States.

Langston Hughes was 17, on a train across the Mississippi at sunset, when he wrote this poem on the back of an envelope. It became the signature opening of his career and a founding poem of the Harlem Renaissance — the explosion of Black literary, musical, and visual culture in 1920s New York. The poem connects Black American experience to a deep, continent-spanning history of African civilization, rejecting the era's racist assumption that Black history began with slavery.

> *Connect: Hughes reclaims African history in his poem. Compare his cultural project to Frederick Douglass's writings (Class 14) — both are Black writers using words to redefine Black identity in America.*

Key Passages

Opening

I've known rivers: I've known rivers ancient as the world and older than the flow of human blood in human veins. My soul has grown deep like the rivers.

The four rivers

I bathed in the Euphrates when dawns were young. I built my hut near the Congo and it lulled me to sleep. I looked upon the Nile and raised the pyramids above it. I heard the singing of the Mississippi when Abe Lincoln went down to New Orleans, and I've seen its muddy bosom turn all golden in the sunset.

Refrain

I've known rivers: Ancient, dusky rivers. My soul has grown deep like the rivers.

HIPP Analysis

Model answers fill the first three rows. Use them to explain the author's Purpose in the last row.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Situation *What was happening when this was written?*	The Great Migration and the Harlem Renaissance after World War I, amid widespread racism, segregation, and violence such as the Red Summer of 1919.
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	Readers of The Crisis, the NAACP's magazine, mostly educated Black Americans, plus white readers interested in Black culture.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	Langston Hughes, a young Black poet who took pride in the African and African American heritage that much of white America dismissed.
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. HIPP — Purpose (1920s media): What is Hughes trying to do by publishing this poem in The Crisis specifically?
2. How does the poem rewrite the geography of ‘Black history’? Page 1 APUSH Class Documents Class 41 - The Negro Speaks of Rivers
3. Connect this poem to ONE other Harlem Renaissance work (Hurston, Locke, Armstrong, Ellington, etc.).

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Langston Hughes · 1921

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> Written when Hughes was seventeen, this landmark poem of the Harlem Renaissance links the depth of Black identity and history to the world's great rivers — from the Euphrates and Nile to the Mississippi.

I’ve known rivers:
I’ve known rivers ancient as the world and older than the flow of human blood in human veins.

My soul has grown deep like the rivers.

I bathed in the Euphrates when dawns were young.
I built my hut near the Congo and it lulled me to sleep.
I looked upon the Nile and raised the pyramids above it.
I heard the singing of the Mississippi when Abe Lincoln went down to New Orleans, and I’ve seen its muddy bosom turn all golden in the sunset.

I’ve known rivers:
Ancient, dusky rivers.

My soul has grown deep like the rivers.

Words to know

Euphrates — river of ancient Mesopotamia, one of the earliest civilizations

lulled — soothed gently to sleep

bosom — chest or breast; here, the river’s broad surface

dusky — dark-colored, echoing both dusk and dark skin